

# Consistency

- Design interfaces to have similar operations and use similar elements for similar tasks
- For example:
  - always use ctrl key plus first initial of the command for an operation – ctrl+C, ctrl+S, ctrl+O
- Main benefit is consistent interfaces are easier to learn and use

# When consistency breaks down

- What happens if there is more than one command starting with the same letter?
  - e.g. save, spelling, select, style
- Have to find other initials or combinations of keys, thereby breaking the consistency rule
  - e.g. ctrl+S, ctrl+Sp, ctrl+shift+L
- Increases learning burden on user, making them more prone to errors

# Internal and external consistency

- Internal consistency refers to designing operations to behave the same within an application
  - Difficult to achieve with complex interfaces
- External consistency refers to designing operations, interfaces, etc., to be the same across applications and devices
  - Very rarely the case, based on different designer's preference

# Keypad numbers layout

- A case of external inconsistency

(a) phones, remote controls

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 4 | 5 | 6 |
| 7 | 8 | 9 |
|   | 0 |   |

(b) calculators, computer keypads

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
| 7 | 8 | 9 |
| 4 | 5 | 6 |
| 1 | 2 | 3 |
| 0 |   |   |